

SOP-009 | Damaged Goods SOP

Evidence collection, severity classification, containment, and authorized disposition.

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Training Notice

This is a fictional internal policy created solely for portfolio development, testing, retrieval, and RAG evaluation. It does not describe the policy of any real carrier, customer, or logistics company.

1. Purpose

Define the standard operating procedure for shipments reported as damaged, including evidence collection, containment, customer handling, and escalation.

2. Trigger conditions

Use this SOP when damage is reported by a carrier, warehouse, driver, receiving customer, or internal inspection.

3. Immediate actions

- Confirm the shipment identifier and affected handling unit or package.
- Prevent further movement when continued handling could worsen the damage.
- Request photographic evidence of exterior packaging, labels, seals, and damaged contents when safe and appropriate.
- Record the reporting party, timestamp, location, and description of visible damage.
- Do not discard packaging or damaged goods until disposition is authorized.

Minimum evidence package: shipment ID, event timestamp, damage description, location, and at least one photo when photos are feasible. Missing evidence must be explicitly noted.

4. Severity levels

Severity	Examples	Required handling
Level 1 - Cosmetic	Scuffed outer packaging; product integrity not affected.	Document and continue unless customer rules say otherwise.

Severity	Examples	Required handling
Level 2 - Functional risk	Crushed packaging, moisture exposure, broken seal, partial damage.	Hold affected goods; Supervisor review within 60 minutes.
Level 3 - Critical	Hazard, total loss, contamination, high-value damage, or unsafe condition.	Stop movement; immediate Supervisor escalation and safety procedures.

5. Customer and claims handling

Customer-facing statements must distinguish confirmed facts from pending investigation. The existence of damage does not by itself authorize a refund, replacement, credit, disposal, or claim settlement.

Financial remedies, replacement commitments, disposal instructions, and claims settlements require authorization under the applicable commercial and finance policies. The AI Logistics Copilot may summarize evidence and prepare a recommendation only.

6. Disposition options

- Continue delivery when damage is cosmetic and product integrity is unaffected.
- Hold for inspection when product condition is uncertain.
- Repackage or recover only when approved and operationally safe.
- Return to origin when authorized.
- Dispose only with explicit authorized instruction and required evidence.
- Open a carrier claim when contractual and evidence requirements are met.

7. Required records

Record	Required
Shipment and package identifiers	Yes
Damage event timestamp and location	Yes
Narrative description	Yes
Photos	When feasible
Carrier or warehouse statement	When available
Customer communication record	If customer contacted
Final authorized disposition	Yes

8. Example

A receiving warehouse reports a crushed carton and broken internal seal. Product condition is uncertain. Classify as Level 2 - Functional risk, place the affected goods on hold, collect the minimum evidence package, and request Supervisor review within 60 minutes. Do not promise a replacement until authorized.

9. Closure

Close the damage incident only after an authorized disposition is recorded and all required evidence is attached or explicitly marked unavailable.

10. Retrieval notes for operational assistants

When answering questions from this SOP, distinguish evidence requirements from authorization. The presence of sufficient evidence does not itself authorize a financial remedy, replacement, disposal, or carrier claim settlement.

Question	Grounded answer
What is the minimum evidence package?	Shipment ID, event timestamp, damage description, location, and at least one photo when feasible.
When is Supervisor review required?	Level 2 damage requires review within 60 minutes; Level 3 requires immediate escalation.
Can the AI approve a refund or replacement?	No. It may summarize evidence and prepare a recommendation only.
Can damaged goods be discarded immediately?	No. Packaging and goods must be preserved until disposition is authorized.

11. Prohibited assumptions

- Do not infer product safety from package appearance alone.
- Do not infer carrier liability before claims review.
- Do not describe a proposed refund, replacement, disposal, or claim as completed unless the authorized system of record confirms it.

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